The Design Mix

Unit 1 · 1.3.3.2 Product / service design

What is the design mix?

Product is the first element of the marketing mix. When designing a product a business balances the **design mix** — three elements that often pull against each other:

- **Function** — how well the product works and meets the customer's practical needs (vital for a kettle or a farm tool).
- **Aesthetics** — how it looks, feels, sounds or smells (vital for an Audi or a Canada Goose coat).
- **Cost (economic manufacture)** — keeping production cost low enough to sell profitably at the target price.

The **most important element depends on the product and market** — a luxury car leans on aesthetics, a budget kettle on cost, a safety tool on function. Trade-offs are unavoidable: more features or better looks usually raise cost.

The design mix & social trends

Social trends increasingly shape design. Businesses adapt the design mix for:

- **Sustainability & resource depletion** — designing for waste minimisation, re-use and recycling (e.g. clothing from recycled plastics).
- **Ethical sourcing** — materials and labour meeting ethical standards, appealing to conscientious consumers.
- **Durability & repairability** — longer-lasting products that reduce waste.

Designing for these trends can add value, justify a premium and protect brand reputation — but usually **raises costs**, so the firm must judge whether customers will pay for it.

Worked examples

- **Lehman's** — sells simple, non-electrical tools that must work reliably, so **function** dominates its design mix.
- **Aston Martin** — uses **aesthetics** to appeal to younger buyers and women.
- **IKEA** — balances function, aesthetics and low cost, and designs for sustainability.